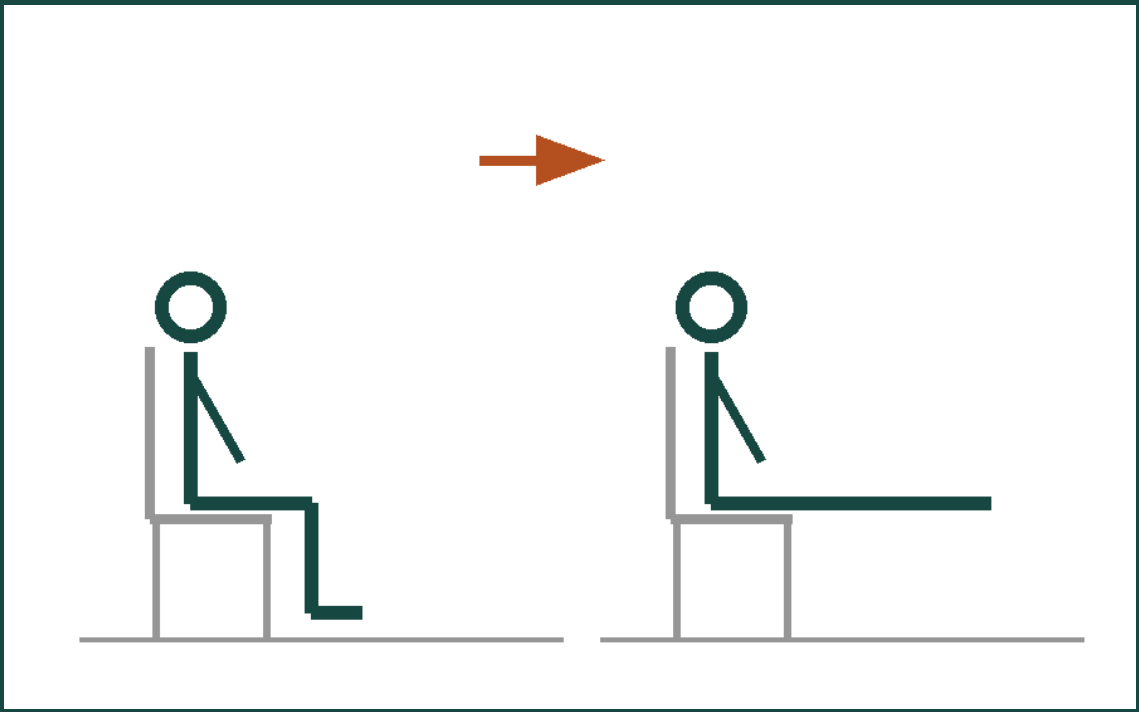
HEALTHY JOINTS DAILY | FREE PRINTABLE GUIDE

7 Morning Moves for Stiff Knees

Gentle | About 5 Minutes | Mostly Seated



Educational only, not medical advice. Talk to your doctor before starting any new exercise routine. Stop if painful.

@HealthyJointsDaily on YouTube

Before You Start

Read this page first

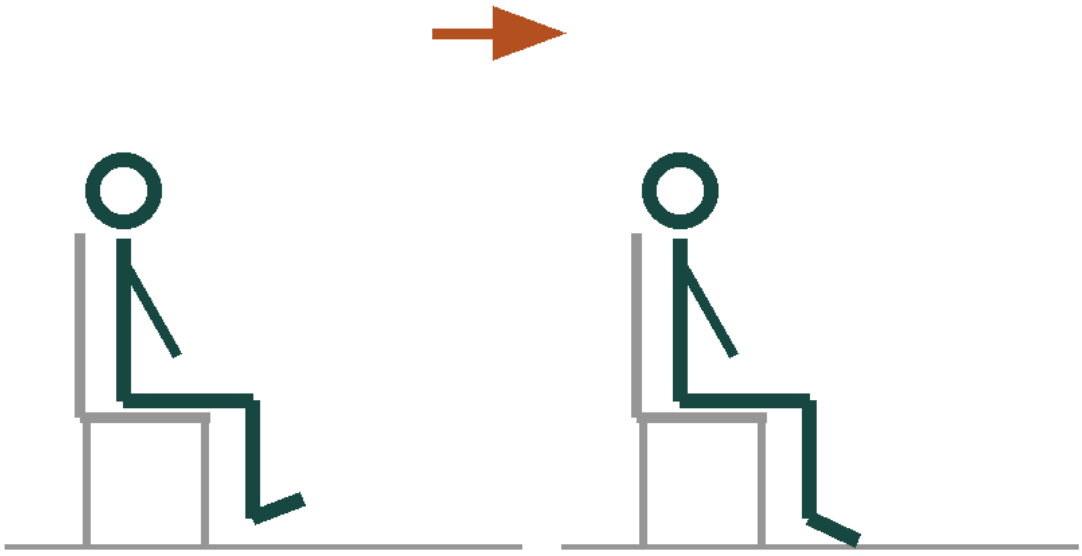
Many of us feel a bit stiff first thing in the morning. This short routine is a gentle way to get moving. Gentle movement may help your knees feel looser and supports everyday mobility.

- You need: a sturdy chair without wheels, and a counter or chair back to hold for Move 7.
- Go slowly. Small movements are fine. Breathe normally.
- Stop if painful. Sharp pain, or pain worse than your usual, is a sign to stop.
- Slow down if you notice swelling around the joint.
- Talk to your doctor or a physical therapist first, especially if you have had surgery, an injury, or a medical condition.
- A warm shower before you begin may help your muscles relax.

Mayo Clinic notes that consistency matters more than intensity. A few minutes most mornings is a great start.

Move 1: Ankle Pumps

Seated | 10 slow pumps



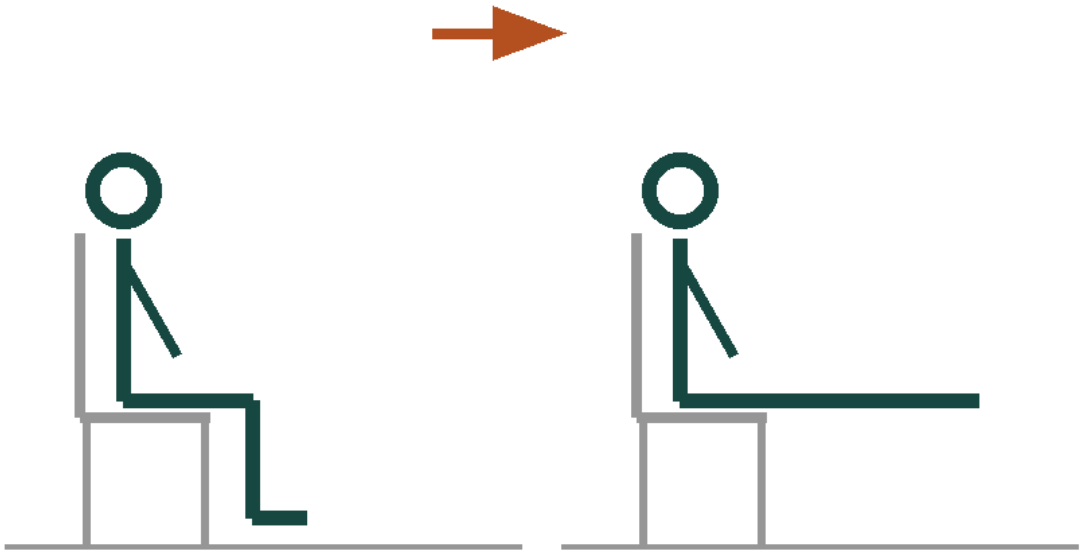
1. Sit tall in a sturdy chair, feet flat.
2. Lift your toes up toward your shins, keeping your heels down.
3. Then press your toes down and lift your heels. That's one pump.

SAFETY TIP

Move slowly and smoothly. Stop if painful.

Move 2: Seated Knee Straighten

Seated | 5-8 per leg, hold 3 seconds



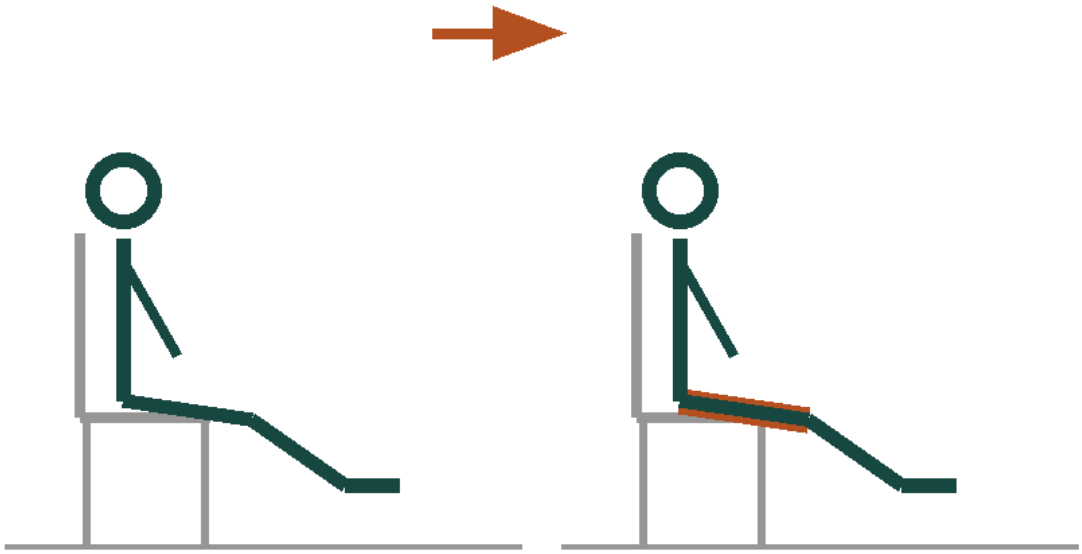
1. Sit tall, both feet on the floor.
2. Slowly straighten one knee until your leg is out in front of you.
3. Hold for about 3 seconds, then lower it slowly. Switch legs.

SAFETY TIP

Don't snap or lock the knee. Stop if painful.

Move 3: Quad Squeeze

Seated | 5 per leg, hold 5 seconds



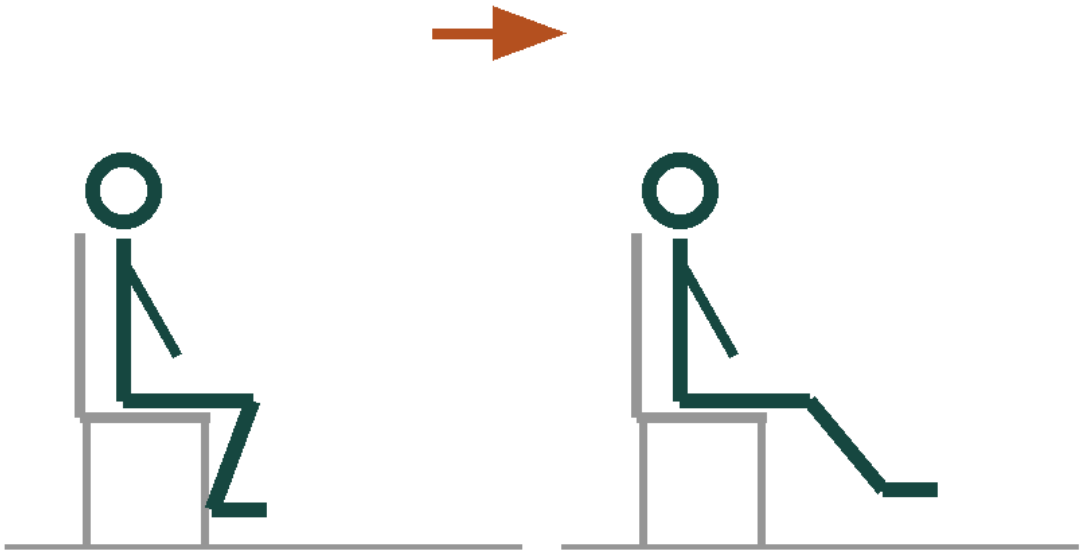
1. Sit near the front of the chair.
2. Rest one heel on the floor with that leg straight out.
3. Gently tighten the muscle on top of your thigh. Hold 5 seconds, relax.

SAFETY TIP

A gentle squeeze is enough. Breathe normally. Stop if painful.

Move 4: Heel Slides

Seated | 8 per leg



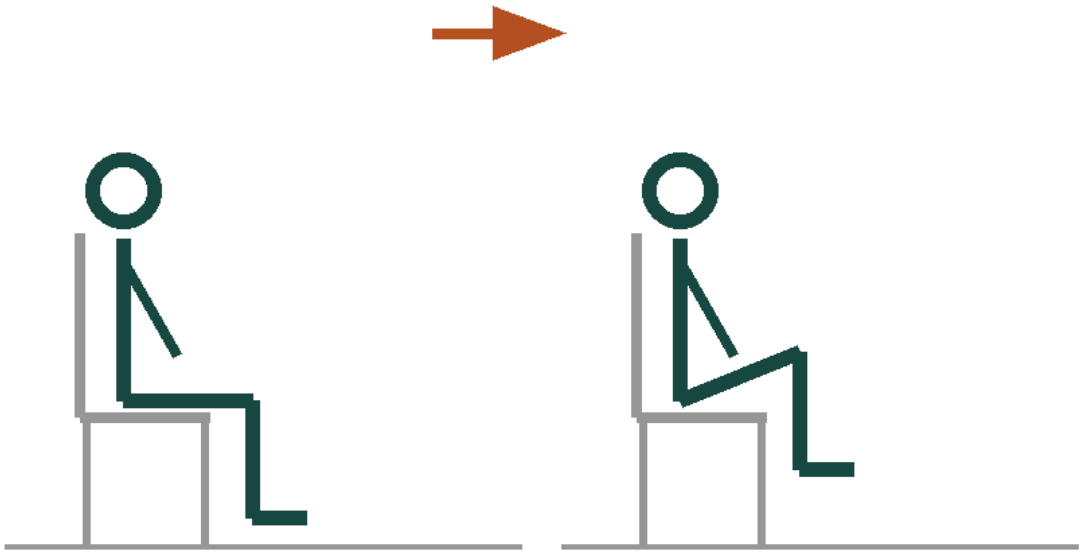
1. Sit tall with one foot on the floor.
2. Slowly slide that foot back under the chair as far as is comfortable.
3. Then slide it forward again. Switch legs.

SAFETY TIP

Only go as far as feels comfortable. Stop if painful.

Move 5: Seated Marching

Seated | 10 per leg, slow



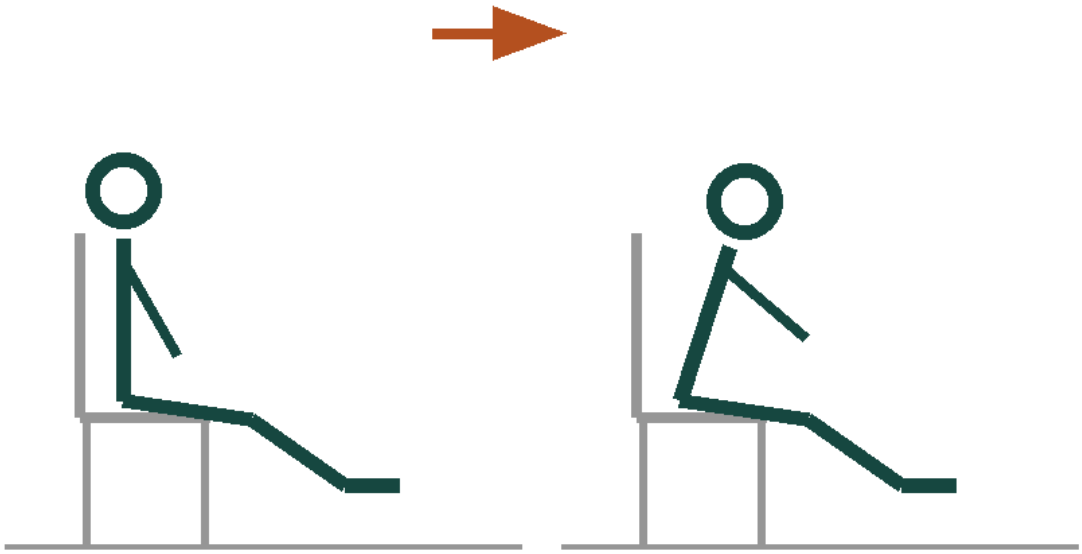
1. Sit tall and hold the sides of the chair.
2. Lift one knee a few inches, then lower it.
3. Alternate legs, like a slow march.

SAFETY TIP

Small lifts are fine. Keep your back tall. Stop if painful.

Move 6: Seated Hamstring Stretch

Seated | Hold 10 seconds, 2 per leg



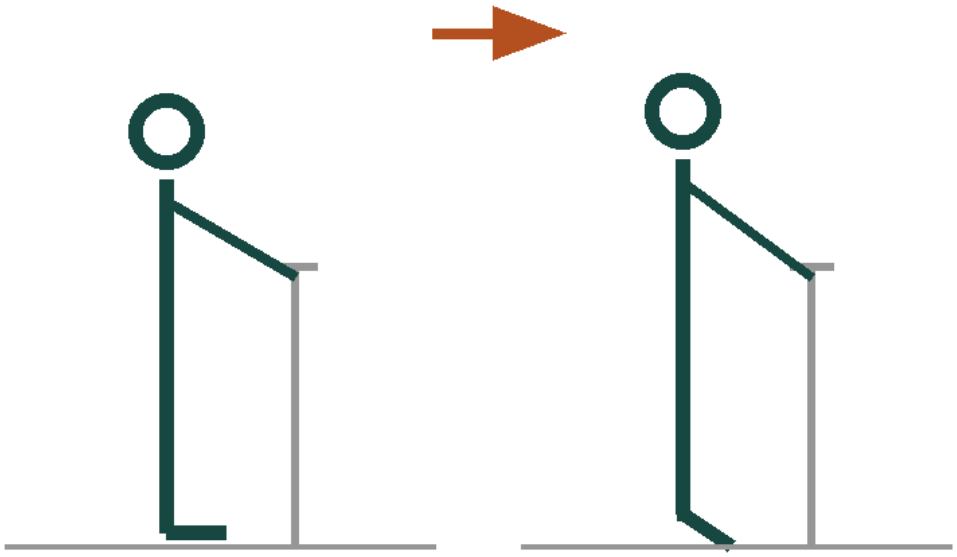
1. Sit near the edge of the chair.
2. Straighten one leg, heel on the floor, toes pointing up.
3. Keep your back straight and gently lean forward until you feel a mild stretch.

SAFETY TIP

A gentle pull, never pain. Don't bounce. Stop if painful.

Move 7: Supported Heel Raises

Standing | 8 slow raises



1. Stand behind a sturdy chair or at a counter, holding on with both hands.
2. Slowly rise up onto the balls of your feet.
3. Then lower your heels slowly back down.

SAFETY TIP

Hold on the whole time and keep knees soft. Stop if painful.

Bonus: Joint-Friendly Habits

Small things you can do every day

- Keep moving most days. Low-impact activities like walking, cycling, or swimming are easier on joints (Mayo Clinic, NIAMS).
- Warm up gently. Range-of-motion moves first, then anything more active (Mayo Clinic).
- Try heat before moving, such as a warm shower or warm towel. Warm, never hot (Mayo Clinic).
- Manage your weight. A healthy weight can help reduce stress on weight-bearing joints like the knees (NIAMS).
- Avoid lots of repetitive bending when you can (NIAMS).
- Gentle tai chi or yoga may help with balance (Mayo Clinic).
- Ask about a physical therapist who can suggest moves that fit you (Mayo Clinic, NIAMS).

Sources

Reputable references used for this guide

Mayo Clinic: Exercise helps ease arthritis pain and stiffness

https://www.mayoclinic.org/diseases-conditions/arthritis/in-depth/arthritis/art-20047971

NIAMS (NIH): Osteoarthritis - Diagnosis, Treatment, and Steps to Take

https://www.niams.nih.gov/health-topics/osteoarthritis/diagnosis-treatment-and-steps-to-take

Arthritis Foundation: Knee Exercises

https://www.arthritis.org/health-wellness/healthy-living/physical-activity/getting-started/your-ex

Arthritis Foundation: 6 Exercises for Knee OA Pain

https://www.arthritis.org/health-wellness/healthy-living/physical-activity/other-activities/6-exerc

This guide summarizes general information from these sources. It is not a substitute for advice from your own doctor or physical therapist.

One More Thing

What I've been looking into

Movement is the foundation. Alongside it, some people also look at joint supplements. One I've been looking into is called Joint Genesis.

I'm not saying it's right for you. Supplements are not a replacement for movement or medical care, and they don't work the same for everyone. Please talk to your doctor before trying any supplement, especially if you take medications.

If you're curious, I put my notes and the official link here:

healthyjointsdaily.vercel.app/?src=web

Affiliate disclosure: If you buy through that link, I may earn a commission at no extra cost to you. This doesn't change what I share.

These statements have not been evaluated by the FDA. This product is not intended to diagnose, treat, cure, or prevent any disease.

Thanks for moving with me. See you tomorrow morning!